

THE EASTERN CAPE PARADOX

The province that helped build South Africa is now asking: where did the leadership go?

By Zola Pinda

There are moments in the life of a country when statistics cease to be statistics.

They become questions.

Why does a province that produced some of South Africa's most consequential political leaders remain among the country's poorest? Why does a region with three strategic ports, an 800-kilometre coastline, major automotive manufacturing, substantial agricultural potential, special economic zones, universities of historic importance and an extraordinary reservoir of human talent continue to struggle to translate those assets into broad-based prosperity?

And perhaps the most uncomfortable question of all:

What happened to the leadership?

This is not an argument against the people of the Eastern Cape. It is an argument for them.

The Eastern Cape is not without history. It is not without talent. It is not without natural resources. It is not without economic opportunities.

It is a province with enormous potential that has repeatedly failed to convert that potential into development at the scale required.

That is why its present condition should trouble the national conscience.

A liberation pedigree cannot repair a broken water system.

The names of Mandela and Tambo cannot substitute for functioning schools.

The memory of Steve Biko cannot become an excuse for failing a generation of young people who have inherited the province.

History matters. But history cannot feed a family.

A province that helped build a nation

The Eastern Cape occupies an unusual place in South African history.

It produced Nelson Mandela, Oliver Tambo, Walter Sisulu, Govan Mbeki, Raymond Mhlaba, Robert Sobukwe and Steve Biko, among many others whose lives shaped the political, intellectual and moral trajectory of the country.

These were not accidental figures.

They emerged from communities, schools, churches, universities, political organisations and rural societies that produced an extraordinary tradition of intellectual and political resistance.

The Eastern Cape was not merely a spectator to South Africa's liberation. It was one of its principal workshops.

That is precisely why its present condition is so difficult to reconcile with its past.

The question is not whether the province deserves sympathy. The question is whether it deserves better leadership.

The numbers are becoming impossible to ignore

The latest provincial figures should make this debate unavoidable.

The Eastern Cape's unemployment rate reached 47.5% in the second quarter of 2026, compared with a national rate of 33.6%.

That is not merely a labour-market statistic.

Behind the number are young people who cannot enter the economy, families surviving largely on social grants, graduates unable to find their first job and rural households whose economic lives remain disconnected from the productive economy.

There is economic activity in the province. There are infrastructure projects, investment initiatives, industrial platforms and employment programmes.

But the scale remains insufficient.

That is the contradiction.

The Eastern Cape possesses substantial economic assets, yet too many of its people remain outside the productive economy.

The question should therefore no longer be simply what government is doing.

Why has the Eastern Cape not yet converted its extraordinary assets into an economy capable of employing its own people?

A province of extraordinary economic contradictions

Consider what the Eastern Cape actually possesses.

It has the Coega Special Economic Zone and the East London Industrial Development Zone.

It has the Port of Ngqura and the Port of East London.

It has a substantial automotive manufacturing base.

It has extensive agricultural land.

It has an extraordinary coastline.

It has tourism assets.

It has renewable-energy potential.

It has universities.

It has a population of more than seven million people.

And yet almost half of its labour force is unemployed.

That contradiction should be at the centre of every serious discussion about the Eastern Cape.

The province does not lack assets. It lacks the institutional capacity and leadership continuity to convert those assets into sufficiently broad economic opportunity.

The money is not the whole problem. Accountability is.

This is where the argument becomes uncomfortable.

The Auditor-General's latest local-government audit outcomes show that only eight of the Eastern Cape's 39 municipalities achieved clean audits, while 17 received qualified opinions and two received disclaimers.

These are not merely accounting outcomes. They are indicators of institutional health.

When public institutions cannot account properly for public money, the consequence is not simply an adverse audit opinion.

It is a road that is not built.

A water project that fails.

A school that deteriorates.

A business that cannot operate.

An elderly person who waits for a service that never arrives.

A young person who concludes that the state has nothing to offer.

The question therefore becomes one of leadership. Who is responsible for ensuring that public institutions work? And what happens when they do not?

The R6-billion school-funding question

The education controversy currently unfolding in the Eastern Cape makes that question even harder to avoid.

The provincial Department of Education conceded in court that its decisions to withhold portions of public-school allocations over several years were unlawful and unconstitutional.

Calculations put the cumulative amount withheld since 2020 at approximately R6 billion. The schools will not receive that money back under the settlement that was made an order of court.

The significance goes beyond the amount. It goes to institutional judgement.

How does a decision of that magnitude survive within a provincial education system?

Who challenged it?

What advice was given?

What warnings were received?

Who was responsible for acting?

And what consequence follows?

These are not questions that should be dismissed as political attacks. They are ordinary questions of accountability in a constitutional democracy.

A court has already determined that the conduct was unlawful. The next question is what the political and administrative system does with that finding.

The elderly cannot become invisible citizens

There is another Eastern Cape story that rarely receives the national attention it deserves.

It is the experience of elderly people in rural communities and small towns.

The elderly often live at the intersection of poverty, unreliable municipal services, electricity problems, transport difficulties and dependence on social grants.

When electricity is disconnected because of municipal debt, when billing systems fail and when basic services become uncertain, it is the elderly and vulnerable who often carry the greatest burden.

This is more than a municipal-service dispute.

It raises a fundamental question about the dignity of citizens who have already spent a lifetime contributing to society.

A pensioner should not have to become a political activist simply to have electricity restored.

The elderly should not be treated as convenient electoral constituencies whose grievances disappear once an election is over.

The dignity of the elderly is one of the most basic tests of a society.

The leadership question

This brings us to the political question.

Oscar Mabuyane's attempt to secure another term as ANC Eastern Cape chairperson has become entangled in a prolonged organisational and legal dispute, including the failure of the provincial leadership to hold its elective conference within the prescribed period.

The issue, however, is bigger than Mabuyane.

What should determine whether any political leader deserves another term?

Political popularity? Organisational support? Factional strength? Electoral performance? Or measurable improvement in the lives of citizens?

A leader cannot be judged solely by his ability to win internal political contests.

The ultimate constituency is the citizen.

The elderly woman in the village. The unemployed graduate. The small farmer. The township entrepreneur. The child sitting in a poorly resourced classroom. The worker travelling hours to a job. The business owner waiting for a municipality to provide basic infrastructure.

Political survival is not the same thing as developmental success.

The irony of the third-term debate

There is an uncomfortable historical irony here.

South Africa has previously witnessed fierce political battles over the extension of leadership tenure.

The debate surrounding Thabo Mbeki's possible third term as ANC president became one of the defining political struggles preceding the ANC's 2007 Polokwane conference.

The lesson should not be reduced to whether Mbeki was right or wrong.

The deeper lesson is that political movements become vulnerable when preservation of leadership becomes more important than performance of leadership.

That principle cannot be applied selectively.

If extended tenure was once criticised as a threat to renewal, the same principle must be examined when political circumstances change.

The question should never be: Is this our leader? It should be: Is this leader delivering?

Where did the Eastern Cape's leaders go?

Perhaps this is the most uncomfortable question of all.

The Eastern Cape has exported people. Lots of them.

Walk through corporate South Africa and you will find Eastern Cape-born executives.

Look through the universities, professions, public institutions, media organisations, law firms, financial institutions and civil society organisations of Johannesburg, Cape Town and Pretoria and you will find people whose formative years were spent in this province.

Many left because Johannesburg offered opportunity. That was understandable.

But the unintended consequence has been the creation of a province that continually exports its human capital.

The brightest young people leave. Established professionals build careers elsewhere. Entrepreneurs often invest elsewhere. Families become geographically dispersed.

And the communities that produced them remain.

The villages remain. The elderly remain. The unemployed remain. The schools remain. The economic potential remains.

What has been missing is a sufficiently powerful coalition capable of bringing that human capital back into a common development project.

The Eastern Cape does not need rescuing. It needs organisation.

This is where I depart from the language of despair.

The Eastern Cape is not a hopeless province. Far from it.

It is one of South Africa's greatest untapped development opportunities.

But potential without organisation is merely possibility.

The province needs leadership capable of bringing government, business, universities, traditional leadership, organised labour, civil society and the Eastern Cape diaspora around one table.

Not another summit. Not another declaration.

A development compact with measurable outcomes.

How many jobs? How many businesses? How many hectares brought into production? How much agricultural output? How many young people trained into actual employment? How many municipalities moved from qualified to unqualified audits? How many schools improved their outcomes? How much private investment actually landed? How many rural enterprises became sustainable?

Those are the questions that should determine whether a government has succeeded.

The diaspora must come home — not necessarily physically

There is enormous Eastern Cape talent in Johannesburg.

That talent does not necessarily have to relocate.

What it needs is a mechanism through which expertise, capital, networks and market access can flow back into the province.

Imagine an organised Eastern Cape investment and expertise network connecting professionals in Johannesburg, Cape Town and abroad with opportunities in agriculture, manufacturing, technology, tourism, renewable energy, logistics and education.

The province should be able to say to its diaspora:

You left. We understand why. Now help us build what you once had to leave behind.

That would be leadership.

The institutions that produced leaders

There is one institution whose story cannot be ignored.

The University of Fort Hare.

For generations, Fort Hare was more than a university. It was an intellectual factory for African leadership.

Its alumni included some of the most consequential figures in the political history of the continent.

That is why its present governance challenges matter beyond the campus gates.

In March 2026, the university's Council placed Vice-Chancellor and Principal Professor Sakhela Buhlungu on precautionary suspension after an investigation found that senior appointments had been made without the required Council approval. Parliament's Portfolio Committee on Higher Education described the move as consequence management.

Further allegations and investigations have followed. Those allegations remain subject to the appropriate investigative and legal processes.

The SIU is also investigating matters relating to Fort Hare. In August 2026, the SIU announced R3.3 million in acknowledgments of debt connected to overcharging in student accommodation and said nine disciplinary cases had been referred.

Fort Hare deserves its own investigation.

We will return to it.

Because the condition of an institution that once helped produce African leaders is inseparable from the larger question confronting the Eastern Cape:

What happens when institutions lose the capacity to produce the leadership society needs?

What would different leadership actually look like?

Not simply different faces.

Different behaviour.

Leadership must establish measurable five-year outcomes.

Not slogans. Not launches. Not political conferences.

Results.

Jobs created. Businesses established. Hectares brought into productive agriculture. Young people trained into actual employment. Schools improving their outcomes. Municipalities improving their audit performance. Water systems functioning. Roads completed. Investment actually landing. Rural enterprises becoming sustainable.

The province also needs an economic compact that survives political cycles.

Agriculture must be treated as an economic sector rather than merely a rural welfare programme.

The ports and industrial zones must be connected deliberately to local businesses.

Universities must be protected from political interference and institutional decay.

And leadership succession must become normal.

A healthy organisation should be able to replace a leader without collapsing.

If an institution becomes paralysed whenever leadership changes are contemplated, the institution has already become weaker than the individual.

Perhaps it is time to ask the women

South Africa has repeatedly asked whether it needs a new political generation.

Perhaps the deeper question is whether it needs a different conception of leadership itself.

Women already carry enormous responsibility across Eastern Cape households and communities.

They run businesses. They raise families. They organise communities. They hold households together when formal institutions fail.

They are teachers, nurses, farmers, professionals, activists and entrepreneurs.

So perhaps South Africa should stop asking: When will women be ready to lead?

And start asking:

When will South Africa be ready to trust the women who have already been leading?

That is a conversation worth continuing.

The Eastern Cape cannot live forever on its history

We must stop romanticising the province merely because Mandela, Tambo, Sisulu, Biko, Mhlaba and Sobukwe came from it.

Their legacy imposes an obligation. It does not provide an exemption.

The generation that fought apartheid understood something that contemporary politics sometimes forgets:

Leadership is ultimately measured by what happens to ordinary people.

Not by how many positions one occupies. Not by how long one remains in office. Not by how many delegates one can mobilise. Not by how successfully one survives a succession battle.

Leadership is measured in the quality of the school. The reliability of the electricity. The dignity of the elderly. The safety of the village. The productivity of the farm. The opportunity available to the young person. The confidence of the entrepreneur. The functioning of the municipality.

And whether a child born in Lusikisiki, Flagstaff, Dutywa, Tsolo, Butterworth, Mdantsane or Mthatha believes that he or she must leave home to have a future.

The question South Africa should ask

Perhaps this is the question that should sit at the centre of the Eastern Cape debate:

How can the province that produced so many leaders for South Africa produce so little leadership for its own development?

That is not an insult to the Eastern Cape.

It is an invitation.

An invitation to its businesspeople. Its academics. Its traditional leaders. Its young people. Its universities. Its churches. Its trade unions. Its civil society. Its municipalities. Its political parties. And its diaspora.

The province does not need another liberation monument. It needs an economic liberation strategy.

It does not need another political slogan. It needs measurable outcomes.

It does not need leaders who merely survive another term. It needs leaders who can point to what changed because they were entrusted with power.

The Eastern Cape gave South Africa some of its greatest political leaders.

The unfinished question of our democracy is whether South Africa — and particularly the Eastern Cape itself — can now produce the developmental leadership capable of transforming that extraordinary legacy into an extraordinary future.

That is the challenge.

And it belongs to all of us.

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Zola Pinda is a Rhodes University-trained journalist whose career has spanned journalism, public-sector leadership, strategic communication and institutional development. His work examines leadership, governance, political history, economic development and the institutions of democratic South Africa.

His journalism is grounded in a simple conviction: public-interest journalism must interrogate power, recover historical context, follow consequences and ask difficult questions about the future.

“A nation cannot correct what it refuses to examine.”

EDITOR'S NOTE

Daily Read is currently being used as a temporary online publishing platform for a developing body of long-form journalism and public-interest commentary. A permanent digital publication platform is being prepared. Readers are invited to return regularly as this growing archive develops.

EDITORIAL TRAIL

The next instalment moves from the crisis of leadership to the making of leaders, examining KK Papiyana, student politics, political education and the generation that entered democratic South Africa carrying enormous expectations.

A forthcoming investigative series, “THE NPA: NDPP BY NDPP”, will examine South Africa's prosecuting authority one National Director of Public Prosecutions at a time — what each inherited, what changed under their tenure, the institutional and political pressures they faced, and what they left behind.